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COVER STORY

The Kellogg Brothers: Health and Wellness Pioneers?

The Kellogg Brothers founded a powerful and impactful cereal company in 1906.

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

They were also innovators in the health and wellness fields and were members of organizations that were ahead of their time - and fought against what was then considered a healthy lifestyle. The Kellogg Brothers left a lasting positive legacy on the health and wellness industry.

The Kellogg brothers' longest-lasting contribution to the Health industry is their product, Kellogg's Cornflakes. Dr. John Harvey Kellogg's (1852-1943) trek towards Kellogg's Cornflakes began as a search for a breakfast substitute to help treat his patients at the Battle Creek Sanitarium who were suffering from stomach problems. [1] This was a consistent complaint of his patients. A disabled gastrointestinal system caused the patient's stomach problems. Dr. Kellogg discovered that the half-baked breakfast mush he had previously been serving patients was causing dyspepsia. He also felt that the replacement should also be "pre-cooked". The creation of Kellogg's Corn Flakes involves conflicting accounts, in which, in the end, Dr. Kellogg, his wife, Ella, and Dr. Kellogg's brother, Will (1860-1951), should receive some credit for its creation. [2]

Dr. John Harvey Kellogg applied to the U. S. Patent Office for his patent on "Flaked Cereal and Process for Preparing the Same"(No.558,399) on May 31st, 1895. [3] The U. S. Patent Office granted Dr. Kellogg this patent on April 14th, 1896. In the patent itself, Dr. Kellogg included flakes made of oats, corn, barley, and other grains in addition to wheat flakes to protect his patent.

In the summer of 1895, Will and Dr. Kellogg introduced the Corn Flakes at the General Conference of the Seventh-Day Adventists at the Battle Creek Sanitarium. [4] The dish became a hit with conference attendees, who would add milk, cream, or yogurt to it.

In 1906, Will Kellogg founded the Battle Creek Toasted Corn Flake Company. [5] In 1907, he changed the

company's name to the Kellogg Toasted Corn Flake Company. [6] In the late summer to early fall of 1907, Kellogg's Cornflakes made its official debut to the American public. [7] It was under Will Kellogg's leadership that, during the Great Depression in 1933, the Kellogg company made a gross profit of \$6 million (about \$110 million in today's money). [8] This was at a time when many companies were going bankrupt or struggling to maintain a profit. In 1939, Will Kellogg retired as the company's head.

Dr. Kellogg was also a trailblazer in other ways in the field of health and wellness. The Battle Creek Sanitarium began in 1866 as the Health Reform Institute. [9] "Sister" White presented her ideas about Christian biblical healthy living at the Seventh-day Adventist General Conference on May 20th, 1866. The General Conference approved the creation of an institute for health reform. [10] It was the governing body of the Seventh-day Adventist Church. The organization opened its doors for business as The Western Health Reform Institution on September 5th, 1867. [11] On October 1st, 1876, Dr. Kellogg became the medical director of the Western Health Reform Institute. [12] The Western Health Reform Institute became the Battle Creek Sanatorium on September 15th, 1910. [13] On the same date, Dr. Kellogg told this audience how the new institution should be called Sanitarium or San, because he felt it better suited the mission. From 1876 to 1943, Dr. Kellogg was at the head of the Western Health Reform Institute, later known as the Battle Creek Sanitarium. [14] Several years before his death, Dr. Kellogg estimated that his work at the Sanitarium

brought him into contact with approximately 250,000 persons. [15]

At the Battle Creek Sanitarium, if a patient were suffering from the “blues,” they would be placed under an electric light cabinet to help them get sunlight. There was not much natural sunlight in southeastern Michigan during the Fall. [16] In this field, Dr. Kellogg was years ahead of his time in terms of medical treatment for seasonal affective disorder or SAD.

In 1916, at the Battle Creek Sanitarium, patient meals were also served with a card attached that specified the proper ratio of calories, proteins, carbohydrates, and fats to be consumed at the meal. [17] An example of this document is dated from May 19th, 1916. This was unheard of in the field of dieting and nutrition at the time.

Kellogg never received credit for this, he encouraged his patients at the Battle Creek Sanitarium, after surgery, to get up, move, and perform graded, deep-breathing exercises.

George Levrier-Jones

Also at the Battle Creek Sanitarium, Dr. Kellogg would lead aerobics and calisthenics with the patients, backed by a brass band. [18] This was so popular that, in 1923, the Columbia Gramophone Company released 10 78-RPM shellac discs of Dr. Kellogg’s class, complete with a booklet. The album was entitled “John Harvey Kellogg’s HEALTH LADDER”. In the booklet, there were exercises for the back, abdomen, legs, and arms that Dr. Kellogg recommended for his patients at the Battle Creek Sanitarium. This was decades ahead of the exercise craze led by Jack Lalanne, Richard Simmons, and other such international figures.

Although Dr. Kellogg never received credit for this, he encouraged his patients at the Battle Creek Sanitarium, after surgery, to get up, move, and perform graded, deep-breathing exercises. [19] This was in stark contrast to the standard procedure of the day, which was to have patients confined to hospital beds for several days to weeks at a time. In the present day, medical procedures, early ambulation, and breathing exercises are the backbone of most recovery protocols after surgery.

In 1934, Dr. Kellogg received a patent for his “Soy Acidophilus Milk”. [20] Dr. Kellogg devised this concoction to deal with babies who couldn’t deal with cow’s milk-based formulae, as well as his patients at the San who were suffering colitis, duodenal or gastric ulcers, babies who rejected their mom’s breast milk, constipation, and excessive flatulence. This was a step forward in addressing digestive and gastric health compared to the treatments of the day. By 1935, patients at the Battle Creek Sanitarium were consuming over 200 gallons a week of Dr. Kellogg’s “Soy Acidophilus

Milk”. The Battle Creek Sanitarium’s patients’ favorite way to enjoy Dr. Kellogg’s “Soy Acidophilus Milk” was with ripe bananas and a side of soy milk. This predated the soy milk craze that you see today all over the world.

Dr. Kellogg and Will Kellogg were pioneers in the fight against tobacco and its harmful effects. Dr. Kellogg had discovered through increasing medical evidence that tobacco smoke caused heart disease, lung disease, digestive disorders, infections, and neurological problems. [21] In 1922, Dr. Kellogg published a successful book entitled Tobaccoism, or How Tobacco Kills . Along with Henry Ford’s book, The White Slaver , these books became a cornerstone of the progressive movement’s failed anti-smoking campaign. Will Kellogg considered smoking to be so dangerous that he demanded that his workers at his factory either quit or he would fire them. He thought tobacco was more dangerous than drinking alcohol. [22]

Dr. Kellogg also thought that tobacco products interfered with proper muscular and growth development, caused gastric ulcers, unduly taxed the liver and kidney systems, injured the brain and nervous systems, and also impaired judgment and moral sensibility. [23] All of Dr. Kellogg’s claims have subsequently been supported by medical science, medical doctors, and research studies, except for the moral sensibility claim.

In the aftermath of World War I, Dr. Kellogg was the president of the Michigan Anti-Cigarette Society and the Committee of Fifty to Study the Tobacco Problem. [24] Henry Ford was also a prominent member of the Committee of Fifty to Study the Tobacco Problem. Dr. Kellogg, with the help of this group, also produced the very first motion picture to address the dangers of tobacco smoking. He and his brother Will were pioneers in their opposition to tobacco products at a time when the tobacco companies were powerful and used their influence to suppress knowledge about the dangers of their products.

In the USA, the dangers of tobacco products did not reach the Federal level until January 11th, 1964, when the Surgeon General issued the 1964 Report on Smoking and Health. [25] In this report, it linked smoking to the cause of emphysema, chronic bronchitis, coronary heart disease, and increased statistical risk of lung cancer. The effects of this report were featured in television and radio reports in the USA and in foreign countries. The Kellogg Brothers knew about the dangers of smoking long before the US government did.

In conclusion, the Kellogg Brothers founded an important cereal company that shaped America’s idea of breakfast. They were also innovators in medical science and wellness. Dr. Kellogg and his brother Will’s opposition to tobacco products was well ahead of its time. The Kellogg Brothers’ beliefs also went against the American and foreign understanding of tobacco and its adverse effects. This was a time when the tobacco Industry held a stranglehold on the public consciousness in America and elsewhere. The

Kellogg Brothers’ courage in publicizing their findings left a legacy on health and wellness concepts that are still felt today.

[14] Markel, Howard. The Kelloggs: The Battling Brothers of Battle Creek . New York: New York. Vintage Books. 2017. 95; Wilson, Brian C. Dr. John Harvey Kellogg: And the Religion of Biologic Living . Bloomington & Indianapolis. Indiana University Press. 2014. XI.

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FEATURES

this monolithic café in south korea is designed to evoke an ancient fortress

kat barandy | designboom · designboom Architecture

Korean studio SOSOKKI ANAC takes to a forested landscape in Gangwon-do to design this Monologue Café as a series of angular brick volumes. The monolithic structure rises from the ground in sharp, deliberate formations. The building reads as a continuous mass, its surfaces folded and inclined, with each plane catching light differently across the day.

Set along a quiet edge of water and low vegetation, the project avoids a single, fixed viewpoint. As visitors move around it, the café shifts in profile, sometimes appearing compact and vertical, elsewhere stretched and low against the terrain. The reddish brick facade gives the structure a consistent material presence, while the geometry introduces variation through depth, shadow, and projection.

images © Seokgue Hong

SOSOKKI ANAC, the architects behind the Monologue Café, begin the design with a speculative concept: a monastery imagined from a time before a reset of the world. This narrative is translated into architecture through the use of layered, faceted forms that suggest accumulation rather than composition. Each volume feels placed in relation to another to build a sense of density and continuity across the site.

References to a monumental boundary condition inform the project's massing, with thick walls and abrupt angles reinforcing a sense of separation and threshold. These gestures are expressed through brick planes that sculpturally tilt, fold, and intersect, thus creating moments where the building reads as both solid and cut.

Monologue Café stands in a forested landscape in Korea as a sculptural brick structure

Interiors shift to an atmosphere of pale surfaces and filtered light. Sloped walls and narrow sections guide movement through the space, creating a sequence of compressed and expanded areas. Seating is arranged along elongated corridors, where tables align with angled windows that frame views outward to trees and ground cover.

Large triangular openings define key moments within the café. These apertures bring in daylight with precision, casting changing patterns across the interior surfaces. The geometry of the openings echoes the exterior form, establishing continuity between inside and outside while also directing attention toward the surrounding landscape.

the building shifts in form depending on movement around its angular volumes

folded brick planes create depth through shadow and a sense of layered mass

the design draws from the concept of a monastery from a forgotten civilization

thick walls and sharp geometries evoke the feeling of a fortress

interior spaces are defined by sloped walls and elongated corridors

materials remain restrained with pale surfaces contrasting the exterior brick mass

project info:

name: Monologue Café

architect: SOSOKKI ANAC | @soso_ant101

location: Gangwon-do, South Korea

lead architects: Gi-tae Chung

technical team: WA20 Architects

general contractor: Starsis

landscape architecture: Natural space

area: 455 square meters

completion: 2025

photography: © Seokgue Hong

The post this monolithic café in south korea is designed to evoke an ancient fortress appeared first on designboom | architecture & design magazine .

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Blue Blooded Guerilla: Stewart Alsop's War Against Nazi Germany. Part I: "Face it, Alsop. You're in Trouble"

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

Battered by wind gusts, the Avro Lancaster bucked and lurched as its crew struggled to keep the plane aligned with the signal fires set by the French Resistance fighters two thousand feet below. The "Lanc," one of the Royal Air Force's (RAF) workhorse bombers, was a homely beast. It had four noisy propellers, a protruding snout, and a pair of ungainly tail fins. Built to drop bombs four miles above Dusseldorf and Dresden, the Lanc was ill-suited for the stealthy parachute operation it was being asked to perform in the predawn hours over Occupied France.

Instead of its usual payload of thousand-pound bombs, the plane was carrying 18 members of two separate cloak-and-dagger outfits. A three-man team – two Americans, one Frenchman – from the ultra-secret Jedburgh program had orders to buttress BERGAMOTTE, a Maquis (Resistance) operation charged with harassing enemy movements on the roads and railways of south-central France.

During their months of training, the Jeds had been taught to mimic the Maqui's tactical mantra: Surprise! Mitraille! Evanouissement! ("Surprise! Kill! Vanish!") Their goal, a Jed team leader mused years later, was to make the enemy believe it was "fighting the Invisible Man."

For weeks, Allied intelligence had worried that the BERGAMOTTE cell was being hounded by the German secret police, the Gestapo. Indeed, the brass feared that the Gestapo had not only seized control of BERGAMOTTE's radio but had compromised its entire operation. The three Jeds were warned that cutthroat German agents – not to mention turncoat Frenchmen, too – might be lurking to snuff any Allied operative parachuted in from England.

"We had been given to understand," the Jed team was to observe in its after-action report months later, "that Mission BERGAMOTTE might conceivably turn out to be the Gestapo in sheep's clothing."

Each Jed was given a personal cipher – an idiosyncratic phrase – to be used in emergency wireless transmissions in the all-too-likely event that they became separated, or if the mission went sideways.

Also waiting to leap out of the plane were 15 members of a coup de main (hard-hitting special forces) group, the Third French Parachute Battalion of the British Special Air Services (SAS). Once behind enemy lines, the SAS "rogue warriors," as British historian Ben McIntyre has tabbed SAS commandos, had their own agenda of mischief and sabotage. Their chief objective was blowing up a bridge along the Route Nationale, the region's main north-south artery, to hobble the Germans' capacity to mobilize troops and armor.

Since the Lanc had no benches, the 18 commandos were sprawled on its floor, cramped against the cigar-shaped supply cylinders that would soon be dumped over their drop zone. An eerie blue light from a single bulb suffused the cabin.

Nine full weeks after D-Day and just two days before the start of the "Champagne Campaign," the Allies' seaborne invasion of the Riviera, Adolf Hitler's Wehrmacht had still not been ejected from France. The Lanc's commandos were about to parachute atop thousands of trigger-happy German grenadiers and panicked Eastern European conscripts (Allied intelligence dismissively called them "Cossacks"), not to mention hundreds of members of the Milice, pro-Nazi Frenchmen who – it was now brutally clear – had backed the losing side.

The Lanc's unlikely first jumper, the 30-year-old American commander of the Jedburgh squad, had already crawled into position above the square hole carved aft of the plane's bomb bay. His name was Stewart Johnson Oliver Alsop. He was the scion of a Connecticut Yankee family whose ancestry could be traced to the Winthrops of Plymouth Plantation.

His facial features mirrored Hollywood matinee idol Robert Taylor's: roguish blue eyes, an elongated patrician nose, mischievous eyebrows, and a mouth that always seemed to be suppressing a smile or a smirk. Even with a mop of brown hair hacked by military barbers, Alsop still radiated a Fitzgeraldian air of old money.

His mother, Corinne Robinson Alsop, was a niece of Theodore Roosevelt, a first cousin to First Lady Eleanor Roosevelt, and a distant cousin of Eleanor's husband, Franklin Delano Roosevelt – or as Stewart's father, a rock-ribbed Republican, called the president, "that crazy jack in the White House!"

A member of the Oyster Bay Roosevelt clan, Corinne had been equally disdainful of her Hudson Valley relation. When the young FDR came to Long Island to court Eleanor, Corinne derided him in her diary as a "feather duster" and hoped Eleanor would have the good sense to dump him.

The Alsops had been Republicans since the Whig Party disintegrated in the 1850s. Stewart's old man, Joseph Wright Alsop IV, was a perennially frustrated Grand Old Party candidate for the Connecticut governorship. Stewart's mother, a cofounder of the Connecticut League of Republican Women, had seconded the nomination of Alf Landon, her party's 1936 presidential nominee. Despite Corinne's stirring oratory, Landon carried only two states against her fifth cousin. Alas, neither of them was Connecticut.

Stewart's older brother by four years, Joseph Wright Alsop V, was already a respected columnist for the New York Herald Tribune and its national syndicate. With war looming in 1941, Joe volunteered for the U.S. Navy. He

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F5: Paige Lawrence on Wildflowers, Vintage Furniture, a Fiddle-Leaf Fig Plant + More

Anna Zappia · Design Milk Architecture

Raised in Texas, Paige Lawrence earned a bachelor's degree from Vanderbilt University before moving to Los Angeles. It was here that an early role in kitchen design and interiors sparked her interest in the built environment.

Lawrence eventually received a graduate degree and became a licensed architect. After several years at a residential firm, she returned to the Lone Star State and joined 787 Design Studio, where she leads the practice alongside founder Patrick Mackie.

The duo is known for thoughtfully-designed homes across Austin and the surrounding region that respond to the natural landscape. For Lawrence, a project always starts with the floorplan. "I thoroughly enjoy the process of getting to know a client's daily life, their routines and rituals," she says. "That understanding is everything, because it's what allows me to design spaces that don't just look beautiful, but genuinely function for the people within them."

To capture her ideas, Lawrence uses a combination of analog and tech. As a self-described doodler, Lawrence almost always grabs a sketchpad, because she loves the tactile feel of pen on paper. She is careful to not make waste with endless scraps, and if multiple iterations are needed, she can easily switch to an iPad.

While Lawrence is busy with career and family obligations, if she could find the time she would try her hand at wood-working or making furniture. "There's something really appealing to me about creating a piece you can actually use, that will sit in someone's home and last," she notes. "And honestly, the technicalities of it suit my type-A mind."

Today, Paige Lawrence joins us for Friday Five !

1. Wildflowers

Growing up in Texas, I've always been in awe of the wildflowers that seem to appear out of nowhere each year. They're a simple surprise that never gets old and bring a quiet sense of joy. I feel a responsibility to care for and preserve them on my own property so this small, magical moment can be experienced for generations to come.

2. Fiddle Fig

I bought this fiddle-leaf fig plant on a whim about 13 years ago when I first moved to Austin. It was barely a foot tall and picked up at a big-box hardware store, with no real plan for what would come next. Since then, it's been through three moves, countless trims, and more neglect than it probably deserved. I've chopped it back many times and propagated smaller versions along the way. Despite my questionable plant skills, it's continued to grow and thrive. It's one of the first things people notice when they walk into our home and has become a lasting part of its identity. I'm excited to see what it becomes next.

3. Dogs

I've always been a dog person and have never been without one. While dogs have brought me a lot of joy, they've also brought heartache. In my early 20s, living in Los Angeles, they pushed me to explore parks and hiking trails I might not have found otherwise. Now, they give our family something to care for, learn from, and gather around. They've become a quiet way to teach our children responsibility while still enjoying the companionship and love dogs bring. We recently adopted our newest dog in what felt like pure fate, and it's been one of the best decisions we've made. He's playful, affectionate, patient with kids of all ages, and a perfect fit for our family.

4. Vintage Furniture

I've always been drawn to patterns and vintage furniture, and when the two come together, it feels like the best of both worlds. These chairs were passed down to me from a family member and won me over immediately. The bold, colorful pattern paired with the simple vintage frame creates an easy balance. They make a statement without trying too hard. That's what I love about vintage furniture, it carries character and presence without feeling pretentious or showy.

5. Sunrises and Sunsets

This may not come as a surprise to some, as I imagine it's a favorite for many. Much like Texas wildflowers, sunrises and sunsets still catch me off guard. Even though they happen every day, their beauty never feels routine. The variety of colors and settings never gets old. A sunrise feels like a new beginning, bringing energy and hope for the day ahead, while a sunset offers a sense of peace and quiet closure. The colors they produce are some of the most magical hues nature creates, and knowing the moment is brief makes it feel special. Like being part of a quiet, shared experience with millions of others.

Works by Paige Lawrence and 787 Design Studio:

With its undulating steel railing and integrated details, this staircase reimagines structure as sculpture, where code, craft, and color converge.

Part bath, part courtyard retreat by 787 Design Studio and Annie Downing Interiors. This light-filled space layers terrazzo, glass, and a freestanding tub within the shower for a fresh take on modern family living.

A contemporary take on the ranch house by 787 Design Studio and Annie Downing Interiors. Breezeways and floor-to-ceiling windows connect living spaces while framing uninterrupted views of the surrounding landscape.

Old World inspired architecture meets modern living by 787 Design Studio and landscaping by LandWest Design Group. A tree anchored plan shapes the experience of the home.

We recently adopted our newest dog in what felt like pure fate, and it's been one of the best decisions we've made.

Anna Zappia

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Stefan Fischer: 500px Photographer Spotlight

500px Blog · 500px ISO

Stefan Fischer's work feels like a series of windows into a world that exists just beyond the reach of our waking hours. His work steps into the surreal, where the gravity of a landscape is interrupted by the ethereal nature of a dream. Capturing nature and recontextualizing it through a creative and sometimes minimalist lens. Fischer's work challenges the viewer to question where reality ends and the subconscious begins.

We sat down with Stefan to discuss the crossroads of design and the camera, the power of silence in an image, and the evolution of his dreamy visual language.

Stefan, thank you for joining us! As an Art Director with a strong foundation in the world of graphic and visual design. How did your experience with design influence your transition into photography?

The goal is to build a bridge between my strategic design thinking and my emotional photography, but I believe that my background in graphic design is the foundation of my photos.

In design, you learn that every element on a page serves a purpose, and you think a lot about balance and visual guidance, and that's exactly how I look through my camera's viewfinder. I don't just see a subject; I see visual hierarchies, lines, and negative space. I don't have to think long; it's more of an instinct, and it just happens.

A camera is a great tool for expressing emotions more directly, rather than just arranging typography and finished images on layouts. Photography allows me to capture the essence of a moment, and for me, that's like real-time design when it comes to storytelling.

When you are conceptualizing a shoot, how much of it is preplanned, or do you take a more spontaneous approach?

I'd say my process is a mix of 80% preparation and 20% chance. I often already have the ideal finished photo in my mind's eye. For that to happen, I need to know the locations inside out, and I often keep visiting a place until the atmosphere there matches, at least roughly, the one in my mind's eye, even though patience isn't exactly my strong suit, and there's nothing I hate more than driving home without any usable material.

There is a distinct quietness to your work that feels almost meditative. In an era where many creators are chasing maximum impact through visual noise and high contrast, why is it important for you to lean into minimalism and negative space?

To me, clarity and minimalism are power, and negative space is not simply empty; it is the space where the viewer can breathe and bring their own thoughts into the picture.

I believe that the most powerful stories are often told in silence, because they force us to look closely.

Perhaps my photos are also a kind of defiant reaction, because we live predominantly in a visual world that is constantly screaming. So why not just take a seat, look at the beautiful landscape, take a breath, and relax a little?

Many of your landscapes have a dreamy, almost surreal quality. What are your criteria for a location? Is it about the literal beauty of the terrain, or are you looking for a specific atmospheric blank canvas that you can later transform?

It's something in between—between reality and vision. I actually often look for places that lose their details in the right light or under certain weather conditions (such as fog, haze, or extreme overexposure). My focus is on reducing things to the essentials, as few backgrounds as possible, or any elements that distract, and definitely not too many people. Even featuring a second person is sometimes almost too much for me. I sometimes achieve this through a specific perspective, such as choosing a vantage point as low as possible, which is why I love subjects situated on a slight elevation, so I can shoot from the bottom up and limit what we can see of the background landscape.

I then try to either enhance or tone down the existing atmosphere in Lightroom, but I never change the overall mood of the photo. You can achieve a somewhat surreal mood quite well through color grading, bringing out or softening shadows, and refining the sky. There are RAW files that have over 20 layers in Lightroom and end up in the trash because I realize they no longer have anything to do with the original mood I captured on location. I don't consider myself a creator of new worlds, even though it's certainly fun.

For a photographer who brings colorful visual elements into different settings, the technical challenge is making the final image feel cohesive. How do you approach the lighting and texture of your composites to ensure that the dream feels as tangible as the landscape?

This consistent look is incredibly important in graphic design. I've had countless discussions about which color scheme to use. I think my own preferences often come into play here; I like pastel shades and warmer tones, though red can sometimes be a bit brighter. I work exclusively with RAW files because you simply have more control over the color grading in post-processing the image, and unlike JPEGs, the dynamic range is greater. So you can intentionally overexpose or underexpose your shots and then correct them in Lightroom. You can achieve amazing effects with overexposure if you experiment a bit.

In the end, I always manage to get something that works together, and of course, post-processing with tools like Lightroom and, to a lesser degree, Photoshop, is just part of the process for me.

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Entrenchments in the U.S. Civil War

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

It seems intuitive that if someone is firing bullets at you, you seek cover, and if no tree or rock or fence is available, to build something protective to hide behind. Yet, the U. S. Civil War was the first armed conflict in which extensive trenches were created. At the beginning, soldiers lined up and fired at those in the opposing line at point-blank range. But the death toll was outrageous; by the end of the war, picks and shovels became as much a part of fighting as artillery and guns.

Entrenchments (also called field fortifications or earthworks) were widely used during the American Civil War, becoming increasingly important as the war progressed.. Trench warfare was not as prevalent as in later conflicts. Except for sieges of fortified cities, combat in the past had been of short duration, major battles rarely lasting for more than a day. Early in the Civil War, we don't see entrenchments at places like Manassas, Shiloh, or Antietam. While fighting behind stone walls and other make-shift barriers was resorted to at various locations, such as Gettysburg, the concept of "digging in" wasn't prevalent until much later. Nevertheless, the development of trench warfare tactics in the Civil War foreshadowed their extensive use in future conflicts.

In discussing entrenchments, therefore, we are not talking about pre-existing stone walls (e.g., Marye's Heights at Fredericksburg) or terrain features (e.g., the Sunken Road at Antietam or Little Round Top at Gettysburg). A "trench" is a deep, long ditch dug into the ground to provide shelter for soldiers from enemy fire, while a "breastwork" is a temporary fortification typically made of earth, built up to chest height, allowing soldiers to fire over it while remaining partially protected from enemy fire; essentially, a breastwork is a more shallow, elevated defensive structure compared to a trench which is a deeper, dug-out ditch. Trenches are significantly deeper than breastworks, often allowing soldiers to stand upright within them. Trenches are dug into the ground, while breastworks are often built up from loose earth or sandbags, sometimes on top of a shallow ditch. While both offer protection, trenches generally provide better cover against heavy artillery and gunfire due to their depth.

The construction of trenches during the Civil War was a labor-intensive process that required organization, manpower, and tools. Commanders would first decide on the location and layout of the trench system. This planning involved selecting high ground when possible, avoiding natural obstacles, and creating a network that provided defensive depth and coverage. Engineer officers would generally plan and supervise. Engineer regiments would assist, if available, but they were limited in number. Most of the work was performed by detailed infantry, perhaps assisted by black labor, free or enslaved, depending on which side.

Soldiers would begin digging the main trench line, typically starting with a shallow trench and gradually deepening it. The soil removed was piled up to create a parapet (a protective wall) in front of the trench to provide additional cover and protection.

Proper drainage was essential to prevent water from accumulating in the trenches. Soldiers would dig drainage ditches and sometimes line the trench floor with wooden planks (duckboards) to keep it dry and prevent mud.

Trenches were often camouflaged to blend in with the surrounding terrain and reduce their visibility to the enemy. Soldiers would use natural vegetation, earth, and other materials to disguise their positions.

"Saps" would be dug forward from an existing trench line, and the new trench extended laterally from there. In addition to the main front-line trenches, support trenches were dug behind the front lines to serve as secondary defensive positions, supply routes, and communication lines. These trenches were connected by communication trenches, which allowed safe movement of troops and supplies between different parts of the trench system..

The construction process was continuous, with soldiers constantly improving and expanding their trench networks to adapt to the evolving battlefield conditions. The resulting trench systems could become extensive and complex, providing significant defensive advantages in the static, attritional warfare that characterized the later stages of the Civil War.

The area surrounding Corinth, Mississippi, was fortified heavily by the Union and Confederate forces who struggled to control the strategically important town. Today, those earthworks are some of the best-preserved in the country. Halleck conceived of Corinth as a quasi-siege, and the concept of building ever-closer lines was a siege stratagem.

Fortifications were made from mounded soil, baskets, timber, and even bales of cotton were very effective. Earth and sod were the primary materials, because they absorbed bullets and shell fragments better than wood or stone. Gabions (wicker baskets filled with earth) were used to reinforce the trenches. To prevent the trench walls from collapsing, soldiers reinforced them with logs, planks, or other materials. In some cases, trenches were lined with sandbags or gabions to stabilize the walls and absorb enemy fire. Trenches were often supplemented with additional fortifications such as earthworks, redoubts (enclosed defensive structures), and gun emplacements. Obstacles like abatis (felled trees with sharpened branches), wire entanglements, and chevaux-de-frise (spiked barriers) were placed in front of the trenches to hinder enemy assaults.

A variety of tools were used to dig trenches, including shovels, picks, axes, spades, and occasionally makeshift tools. Soldiers themselves did the digging early on. Over time, both the Union and Confederate armies

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Repeat Bexar County gambling raid leads to arrests and cruelty cases

Suswati Basu · ReadWrite

Authorities in Bexar County moved again Thursday (March 19) to shut down what they describe as an illegal gambling operation in San Antonio, returning to a property that has already drawn law enforcement attention in recent years. The enforcement action unfolded alongside two separate animal cruelty investigations elsewhere in the county.

Sheriff Javier Salazar said investigators with the Organized Crime Unit acted on newly developed intelligence pointing to renewed activity at the same location raided in 2022.

“We’re out here at the scene of a gambling operation,” Salazar said in a press conference. “This location... is one that we’ve hit previously.”

Deputies arrived before any active gambling began but still encountered several people gathered at the property. Three individuals were released at the scene, while two others were arrested, one for drug possession and another on an outstanding theft warrant.

Authorities also forced open a large safe with assistance from the fire department. Inside, they found what Salazar described as “a large amount of cash,” though officials have not yet determined the total.

Investigators believe additional charges could follow, potentially including organized criminal activity tied to the property’s owner.

“There is a distinct possibility we may be charging that owner... with engaging in organized criminal activity,” he said.

Salazar said the setup suggested the location had been prepared to continue operating despite prior raids. While the gaming machines themselves are not necessarily illegal, he explained that offering payouts beyond what state law allows turns the activity into a criminal enterprise.

Another view inside the raided San Antonio gambling site, showing machines, decorations, and gaming areas seized by authorities. Credit: Bexar County Sheriff’s Office via Facebook

He also warned about the broader community impact, saying these operations often draw vulnerable patrons and overlap with other criminal activity.

“The folks that most often are targeted by these places... are usually elderly people that are on a fixed income,” Salazar said. “But you mix that in with... people in possession of guns, people in possession of drugs—and it’s certainly not a good mix.”

Earlier that same day, deputies responding to a report about possible squatters instead discovered multiple dogs living inside an RV under hazardous conditions on Elm Forest.

The interior was heavily contaminated with waste, and officials said ammonia levels reached 16 percent, creating an immediately dangerous environment.

“Just caked feces and urine... extremely deplorable conditions,” Salazar said. “So much so that we had to back out because of the strong ammonia smell.”

Seven dogs were removed and transferred to Bexar County Animal Control. All survived, though authorities expect animal cruelty charges. Investigators are still working to determine whether the situation involves hoarding or unregulated breeding.

In a separate case the night before, deputies arrested a resident after finding a severely underweight dog confined to a balcony at a home on Mansion Bluff. Neighbors had raised concerns after noticing the animal’s declining condition.

“There’s really no excuse for keeping an animal like that,” Salazar said. “If you cannot adequately take care of your pet... give it to somebody else.”

The dog, estimated to be about seven years old, is now receiving treatment and is expected to be rehomed.

Officials noted that both the gambling property and the RV had drawn repeated complaints in the past. Previously in Texas, Bexar County authorities detained 22 people during a large-scale gambling raid.

Salazar said enforcement will continue as long as illegal activity persists.

“As many times as they keep opening, we’ll keep coming back and knocking them down.”

Featured image: Bexar County Sheriff’s Office via Facebook

The post Repeat Bexar County gambling raid leads to arrests and cruelty cases appeared first on ReadWrite.

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World War 1 Hero - Jack Cornwell, Royal Navy - Victoria Cross

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

Jack Cornwell was born on the 8th of January, 1900 in Leyton, then part of Essex, into a working-class family for whom life offered few comforts and little security. He grew up in modest surroundings and attended local schools, where he was remembered as a quiet, unassuming boy rather than an exceptional student or natural adventurer. Like many boys of his generation, Cornwell was drawn to the Royal Navy by a mixture of patriotism, the promise of steady pay, and the romance of the sea. At just fifteen years old he enlisted as a Boy Seaman in 1915, undergoing training at HMS Impregnable before being posted to active service at an age when most of his contemporaries were still in school.

In early 1916 Cornwell was assigned to HMS Chester, a newly commissioned light cruiser of the Royal Navy's 3rd Light Cruiser Squadron. As a Boy First Class, his duties included serving as a sight setter and loader on one of the ship's 5.5-inch guns, a demanding role that required discipline, precision, and physical stamina. Despite his youth, Cornwell adapted quickly to the routines of naval life and the responsibilities of combat readiness. By the end of May 1916, Chester was operating in the North Sea as part of the British Grand Fleet, soon to be drawn into the largest naval engagement of the First World War.

The Battle of Jutland, fought between the 31st of May and the 1st of June 1916, was the long-anticipated clash between Britain's Grand Fleet under Admiral Sir John Jellicoe and the German High Seas Fleet commanded by Vice-Admiral Reinhard Scheer. Both sides sought to gain decisive control of the North Sea, a strategic prize that would shape the course of the war. The British aimed to maintain their naval blockade of Germany, while the Germans hoped to weaken British sea power by isolating and destroying portions of the Grand Fleet. The battle unfolded amid confusion, smoke, poor visibility, and rapidly shifting tactical situations, with dozens of capital ships and cruisers exchanging fire over vast distances.

HMS Chester became engaged during the early phases of the battle when she encountered a group of German light cruisers. Outgunned and exposed, Chester came under intense and accurate enemy fire. Several German shells struck the ship, causing heavy casualties among the gun crews. One shell burst close to Cornwell's gun position, killing or disabling nearly the entire crew and inflicting severe wounds on Cornwell himself. He suffered multiple injuries to his chest and legs, wounds that would ultimately prove fatal. Despite his pain and loss of blood, Cornwell refused to leave his post. Standing alone amid the wreckage, he continued to load and aim the gun, awaiting orders and prepared to fire if commanded.

Cornwell remained at his station until the fighting subsided and Chester withdrew from the action. Only then was he discovered by officers, still upright beside the gun,

gravely wounded but steadfast in his duty. He was taken to the hospital upon the ship's return to port, but his injuries were too severe. Jack Cornwell died on the 2nd of June 1916, just over a day after the battle, at the age of sixteen. His conduct, marked by extraordinary courage, discipline, and devotion to duty in the face of overwhelming danger, was soon reported to the Admiralty.

Standing alone amid the wreckage, he continued to load and aim the gun, awaiting orders and prepared to fire if commanded.

George Levrier-Jones

In recognition of his actions, Cornwell was posthumously awarded the Victoria Cross, the highest award for gallantry in the British and Commonwealth armed forces. The citation emphasized that he "remained standing alone at a most exposed post, quietly awaiting orders," despite being mortally wounded. His youth made his bravery all the more striking, and his story resonated deeply with a nation exhausted by war and loss. Cornwell was given a hero's funeral in London, attended by thousands, and his grave became a site of public remembrance.

The Battle of Jutland itself remains a subject of debate among historians. Tactically, the German Navy could claim a measure of success, having sunk more British ships and inflicted heavier immediate losses. However, strategically, the battle was a clear victory for Britain. The Royal Navy retained command of the sea, and the German High Seas Fleet, though not destroyed, was effectively contained. After Jutland, the German fleet rarely ventured out in strength again, conceding naval dominance to Britain and ensuring that the blockade of Germany remained intact for the remainder of the war.

Jack Cornwell's legacy endures as one of the most powerful symbols of youthful courage in British military history. He was not a seasoned warrior or a decorated officer, but a teenage sailor who, when tested under the most extreme conditions, displayed unwavering resolve and selflessness. His story embodies the quiet heroism of ordinary individuals caught in extraordinary circumstances. It serves as a reminder that courage is not measured by age or rank, but by the willingness to stand fast in the face of fear and duty.

Jack Cornwell's story endures not because it is dramatic in the conventional sense of battlefield heroics, but because of its profound simplicity. In the chaos and terror of Jutland—the smoke-filled decks, the thunder of naval guns, and the sudden loss of comrades around him, Cornwell did not perform a single spectacular act meant to turn the tide of battle. Instead, he did something far rarer and more revealing: he stayed. Mortally wounded, isolated, and fully aware of the danger, he remained at his post, embodying the quiet discipline and sense of duty instilled in him by the Royal Navy and embraced by him as a personal

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Why sustainable products fail—and what actually gets people to use them

Goutam Challagalla · Fast Company Design

Here's a story you're probably familiar with: You buy the reusable coffee cup. It's beautiful, ethical, made from recycled ocean plastic, and you feel good about your purchase. But then it leaks in your bag, ruins a notebook, and by week two it's sitting in a cabinet while you're back to disposable cups and a vague sense of guilt.

Or maybe it's the "eco mode" on your washing machine that takes three hours instead of one. The sustainable packaging that requires scissors, sweat, and a YouTube tutorial. The electric vehicle charging app with six steps when a gas pump has one.

We've all been there. But here's what's interesting: The problem isn't that you don't care about sustainability. It's that these products are designed as if caring should be enough.

And the problem for businesses with this approach is that it's not.

There's a gap that kills sustainable products, and it's not about values. It's about friction.

In our research, we have examined hundreds of companies across many industries and found the same pattern: Products fail when they ask people to care more. They succeed when they ask people to do less.

The difference seems subtle but it's not. Caring is an intention. Using is a behavior. And between intention and behavior sits everything that makes us human: cognitive load, time pressure, habits, trade-offs, the path of least resistance.

People don't usually buy products to express values. They buy them first to solve problems with the least effort possible. When you add steps, costs, or complexity in the name of sustainability, you're competing with convenience. And in this battle, convenience almost always wins.

The question shouldn't be, How do we get people to care more? Rather, it should be How do we design sustainability that works because it's easier, not despite being harder?

When you map how sustainability actually intersects with product experience, you see three outcomes.

Sustainability that's neutral. It doesn't help or hurt the core value proposition. Maybe it's a recycled component the user never notices. It doesn't drive adoption, but it doesn't kill it either.

Sustainability that adds friction. Extra steps. Higher up-front cost. Performance trade-offs. Packaging that's harder to open. This is where good intentions go to die.

Sustainability that improves the experience. Lower lifetime cost. Fewer decisions. Better performance. Less maintenance. This is where adoption happens, and it's rarer than it should be.

That third category is where things get interesting.

Take Electrolux. A few years ago, the company redesigned its washing machines with a specific goal: Make clothes last longer.

Not "wash greener" or "use less water," but simply "make clothes last longer."

The machines became gentler on fabrics. Garments held their shape, color, and overall integrity through more wash cycles. For consumers, that meant real money saved over time, and fewer worn clothes that needed replacing.

To be sure, energy and water use dropped too. Textile waste fell. Microplastic shedding from synthetic fabrics declined.

But here's the key: Customers didn't adopt a sustainability feature. They adopted a better washing machine—one that made their lives easier and saved them money. The environmental benefits were an extra.

Or consider John Deere, which shifted from selling machines to selling productivity. Using GPS, sensors, and software, farmers can now optimize exactly where and when to plant, spray, and harvest.

The result? They use significantly less fuel and fewer chemicals while improving yields. Operating costs fall. Regulatory compliance gets easier.

Farmers didn't "go green." Rather, they optimized their operations, and sustainability was the side effect of better data and smarter systems.

Even in heavy industrial markets, the same logic applies. Siemens embeds sustainability into automation and energy systems by making them more efficient, more reliable, and cheaper to operate over their life cycle. Customers adopt because the total cost of ownership drops and uptime improves. The emissions reductions are real, but they're not what closes the sale.

In each case, sustainability doesn't ask customers to sacrifice. It delivers something they already wanted, but better.

These examples have one thing in common: Sustainability works when users barely notice it.

The Nest thermostat learns your patterns instead of asking you to program schedules. Spotify optimizes streaming quality based on your connection instead of making you choose bit rates. Modern cars shift gears better than you can, and are more efficient on the engine, so we stopped asking people to shift manually.

The best sustainable products follow the same principle.

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How architects design airports to handle superlong security lines

Nate Berg · Fast Company Design

The historically long security lines currently snaking through U. S. airports are the painful result of extreme circumstances. Callouts, no-shows, and resignations by Transportation Security Administration workers fed up with a lack of pay during a partial government shutdown, combined with a bump in spring break travelers, have created unusually congested airport security checkpoints.

For the architects and airport authorities that work together to design these heavily regulated spaces, it's the kind of convergence you can't exactly plan for. But, according to some of the designers of these spaces, airports are increasingly incorporating design features that can help them manage extreme security lines in the future.

George Bush Intercontinental Airport (IAH) in Houston
[Image: Stantec, in collaboration with Grimshaw]

The lines, though currently caused by TSA worker shortages, are actually governed by the airports themselves and therefore are the airports' problem. "There are regulations, but what the TSA is really interested in is the point from where you have your last document checked, called the TDC, to the actual [scanning] equipment," says Ty Osbaugh, principal and global aviation leader at Gensler, a design and architecture firm. "That's their land. How the queue works is purely up to an airport."

How big that queue gets, though, is out of the airports' and their designers' hands.

Controlling the lines leading up to the security checkpoint takes a lot more than setting up a maze of stanchions. Osbaugh says airports carefully plan their pre-security, or landside, spaces to manage flows of passengers that can vary wildly during different times of the day and different days of the year. Building flexibility into this area, which can often share space with ticketing areas, allows for the lines to adapt to the crowds and circumstances.

Gensler is currently working on a \$9.5 billion redesign of Terminal 1 at John F. Kennedy International Airport in New York City, and Osbaugh says the landside space was designed with softer edges to be able to accommodate overflow. "We've got a garden that's [adjacent], so if the queue starts to back up—God forbid that it does—now people have that extra space to be able to queue instead of backing into the ticketing areas and everything," he says.

Other airports, including some currently experiencing incredibly long security lines, don't have this kind of flexibility. "That's the problem that we see in Hartsfield right now," Osbaugh says, referring to the Hartsfield-Jackson International Airport in Atlanta, where travelers have been advised to expect four-hour wait times. "The checkpoints are boxed in by hard elements on both sides. So it's just trying to figure out how do you have that pressure relief valve in the queue?"

IAH Airport [Image: Stantec, in collaboration with Grimshaw]

Airports are designed with epic security lines in mind, but that doesn't mean they are built around the chance that they occur. Jonathan Massey, managing principal and aviation sector leader at the architecture firm Corgan, says his firm's approach is to understand the existence of outlier events, but to design for more realistic peaks. "You always know something's going to happen. There's going to be a snowstorm somewhere, there's going to be a strike, there's going to be a terrorist event, there's going to be a pandemic," he says.

Things like pandemics, strikes, government shutdowns, blizzards—those fall outside of that," he says.

Nate Berg

Airports rarely end up being large enough to handle abnormally high crowds that may only occur once every few years. Massey says airports are designed to accommodate predictable peak surges like spring break, the summer travel season, and Thanksgiving. "We'll look at those as our planning baseline. Things like pandemics, strikes, government shutdowns, blizzards—those fall outside of that," he says. "Typically, the industry just isn't willing to spend \$1,000 a square foot to make a building bigger for what might happen."

Airports can also be hesitant to try to solve unpredictable crowding problems in facilities that will stand for decades, especially as new security technologies are rapidly changing the checkpoint process. Osbaugh, who's been designing airport projects since before the September 11, 2001, terrorist attacks, recalls a time when the security screening was an agent waving a metal detecting wand. "The one thing that is constant, and will continue to be constant as it relates to security checkpoints, is they are going to evolve," he says.

When it begins opening in phases later this year, the new Terminal 1 at JFK Airport will integrate biometric document-checking technology that could, one day, eliminate the need for human workers to manually check identification and boarding passes. "It's taking the need of staffing for airlines down to next to none, but it's also reduced the footprint of how much space is needed at a check-in hall," Osbaugh says. The lines leading up to this checkpoint, he adds, can "accordion" in size depending on the size of a crowd at any given time.

Such flexibility has some architectural implications. Jeff Mechlem, airport sector leader at the architecture and engineering firm Stantec, says it's become more important for airport designs to have wide open areas for the entire security pipeline. "[We're] looking to make sure we can reduce the amount of columns and permanent walls and such that restrict not only the changing equipment and technologies, but also the configuration of our queues," he says.

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TIMM Architecture fronts House of Iron Doors with weathered steel shutters

Jon Astbury · Dezeen Architecture

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Georgian studio TIMM Architecture has completed House of Iron Doors, a home on the outskirts of Tbilisi that features an openable facade of perforated weathered steel shutters.

TIMM Architecture aimed to transform the aesthetic of high fences and walls of man homes in the neighbourhood into “an architectural experience rather than a defensive barrier” for this house in the village of Okrokana.

TIMM Architecture has created a house in Georgia

“The project began with a simple observation: in many suburban contexts the wall becomes the most dominant architectural element, while the house itself disappears behind it,” the studio told Dezeen.

“Exploring the relationship between wall, facade and garden led to a key question: what if the perimeter wall itself became architecture?”

It is fronted by weathered steel shutters

House of Iron Doors sits slightly raised above ground level, with an L-shaped plan that hugs a rear garden and is buffered from the street behind a strip of planting.

The street-facing section of this volume has been almost entirely given over to a large, glazed living area, which the facade’s shutters allow to be either completely open or closed, with light filtering in through small circular perforations.

There is a large glazed living area

Opposite, sliding glass doors open the living area and the adjacent dining room onto the central courtyard, facing a wall of weathered steel covered in metal mesh to support climbing plants.

“When the doors are fully opened, the house behaves almost like a pavilion where interior and exterior merge into a continuous living environment,” said the studio.

“The spatial atmosphere changes depending on the position of the facade panels: when closed, the house feels protective and introspective; when opened, it becomes transparent and outward-looking.”

The shutters filter light into the living room

TIMM Architecture chose weathering steel to create what it called an “infrastructural presence” on the street, with a monolithic appearance when the shutters are closed that is contrasted by the home’s minimal, largely monochromatic interiors.

The perpendicular wing of the home contains two storeys of bedrooms, while above the living area a swimming pool opens out onto a rooftop terrace via sliding glass doors.

Read:

Ten ways that architects used weathering steel in 2025

“Material selection was guided by the conceptual idea of the façade as both boundary and mechanism,” explained the studio. “Weathered steel was chosen for the operable doors because it expresses solidity, durability and transformation.”

“Other materials are intentionally restrained and minimal, allowing the movement of the facade and the spatial relationships of the house to remain the primary architectural expression,” it continued.

The home features a courtyard

Beneath the home, a basement floor contains a garage accessed via a ramp at the front of the home, as well as a games room, utility and storage spaces.

Other projects that have recently incorporated large shutters include an office in Fujisawa City by Schemata Architects, which features a facade of operable corrugated metal shutters.

The post TIMM Architecture fronts House of Iron Doors with weathered steel shutters appeared first on Dezeen .

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Boshin and Satsuma: The Fall of Feudal Japan

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

Gabriele Esposito's book, *Japanese Armies 1868-1877: The Boshin War and Satsuma Rebellion* (Osprey Publishing 2020), is an excellent summary of two significant conflicts that forever transformed Japan. A short but informative read, it covers historical events adapted for the famous movie *The Last Samurai*, starring Tom Cruise and Ken Watanabe.

For hundreds of years Japan had been ruled by a mere figurehead—an emperor with a religious function but little genuine authority—with all real power in the hands of the shogun, the hereditary military leader of Japanese society. The shogunate, as the central authority was known, implemented an extreme isolationist policy, keeping Japan religiously and culturally pure from Western barbarian influences.

Maintaining a decentralized feudal society, “Japan” as an institution could barely be said to exist. It was separated into 250 domains ruled almost autonomously by local lords as independent feudal states. Families of daimyo warlords parceled out lands to samurai warriors who could be called upon in times of war or for policing. Feudal Japan was a highly hierarchical society, with peasants at the bottom of the pile.

However, Japan was forced to open to Western nations in the 1850s due to American intimidation, bringing in new ideas and new goods. Disagreement and dissent arose within Japan over whether to modernize to protect itself and maintain its independence, or to isolate itself further. Beginning in 1860, isolationists began making moves within Japan to bring down the shogun and place the emperor in full authority. In 1863, the emperor called for the expulsion of all foreigners from Japan, and many Westerners were murdered. The shogunal forces received aid from the West, seeking to modernize their navy and army. Various feudal clans supported either the shogun or the emperor, leading to the Boshin War.

Jules Brunet (played by Tom Cruise in the movie as the American officer Nathan Algren), a western military advisor and trainer, was ordered to return to France but disobeyed, instead fighting with a small contingent for the shogunal forces even after their eventual defeat. The imperial forces led by Saigō Takamori (who later became famous for defending the samurai against the centralized, modernized Japanese government during the Satsuma Rebellion) were victorious, pushing their opponents into northern Japan. Now with modernized weapons, the shogunal forces continued the fight as it raged back and forth, but the feudal clans and Brunet were forced out of Japan's main and largest island Honshu, fleeing to the northern tribal island of Hokkaido, where all those still loyal to the shogun gathered.

In 1868, Brunet helped form a new government and trained the army on Hokkaido. But the imperial forces'

naval supremacy and technological advantages helped capture the island, and Japan became united under the emperor in 1869. Brunet escaped.

Japan became a centralized, unified country and opened to the west (initially, the emperor had been opposed to western intervention) and began dismantling the decentralized local lordships, as well as any remaining elements of hierarchy or inheritance. The military was modernized, and the samurai were left behind. Public education, national tax, industrialization and more transformed Japanese life, while outlawing the samurai weapon of swords. Class distinction vanished, at least in theory, hierarchy replaced with equality.

Traditionalists were once more outraged, especially the Samurai clans, leading to the secession of the traditionalist Satsuma territory, led by “The Last Samurai,” Saigō Takamori, and other dissident samurai. They openly rebelled in 1877. Samurai wore traditional outfits and armor, and used swords as a protest against their being illegal and outlawed. Most fought and died this way.

The imperial, modernized Japanese army greatly outnumbered the rebels and maintained significant technological advantages. Despite this, massive battles raged with heavy losses on both sides, before the samurai and their allies were forced to retreat and engage in guerrilla tactics while hunted down by imperial forces. Eventually, they lost all their gunpowder units and their numbers dwindled, yet they kept fighting for months on end. Then, the final 3,000 or so chose Mount Enodake as a last defensible position. Surrounded and vastly outnumbered, their defeat was inevitable; many committed seppuku (ritual honorable suicide) rather than surrender to their foes.

However, as he had done multiple times before, Saigō escaped, and with the last 500 samurai armed with swords and traditional weapons chose a literal last hill to die on; opposing him was an imperial army of 30,000.

Saigō was among the last 40 or so samurai in the battle who made a final headlong charge at the enemy, was wounded multiple times, and committed seppuku with the help of an aide. All of them died in battle, preferring death to dishonor.

Jeb Smith is an author and speaker whose books include *Defending Dixie's Land: What Every American Should Know About The South And The Civil War* written under the pen name Isaac C. Bishop, *Missing Monarchy: Correcting Misconceptions About The Middle Ages, Medieval Kingship, Democracy, And Liberty* and he also authored *Defending the Middle Ages: Little Known Truths About the Crusades, Inquisitions, Medieval Women, and More*. Smith has written over 120 articles found in several publications.

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Studio Blur models Quito arts school after Le Corbusier house

Kate Mazade · Dezeen Architecture

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Local design practice Studio Blur has created a concrete building with a sawtooth roof for the visual arts department of a school in Quito, Ecuador.

Known as Aulas de Arte at the Unidad Educativa Cardenal Spellman, or the Visual Arts Building at the Cardinal Spellman Salesian Bilingual School, the 142-square metre (1,528-square foot) project opened in 2024 on a 3-acre plot that already contained a classroom building, church and gymnasium.

Studio Blur has designed a concrete arts school in Quito

The three-storey, wedge-shaped building allowed for an adjacent green space that reinvigorated and reconnected the campus.

Studio Blur's design was informed by modernist architect Le Corbusier's design for the house and studio of Amédée Ozenfant, a 1922 Paris building that has inspired architects such as Juan O'Gorman and David Chipperfield.

Its design was informed by a Le Corbusier building

"There must be something profound in that foundational work that continues to justify its study," the studio told Dezeen.

"We hope that through this reference, one may discern an echo of what our art building aspires to be – and perhaps, a trace of that inspiration which once guided us."

Green space connecting the building to the wider campus was revamped

Like the Ozenfant House, the arts building is driven by natural lighting that creates unique atmospheres for different activities at distinct times.

"This dynamic interaction between light and architectural structure generates rich environments that enhance the sensory experience while reinforcing the narrative," the studio said, explaining that the monolithic concrete structure and strategic openings allowed it to animate the building from the thresholds.

Read:

Krft sculpts "bulging" form for Brighton College arts centre

The plan is organised around a diagonal axis with a basement containing service spaces that look up and out to the stepped garden. The ground floor contains a graphic design classroom with controlled openings that maximise natural light and ventilation while minimising external noise.

Meanwhile, the crowning upper level houses a painting studio with diffused, homogeneous light that filters into the space through a large bay of windows and three sawtoothed skylights.

The school is topped with a sawtooth roof

Each of the floors is connected by a rounded double-run staircase that loops across the intersection of the arts wing and the classroom building, bridging the new and old structures with white, speckled terrazzo.

The exterior of the building is exposed concrete, expressing the interior form and structural logic. Two post-tensioned slabs leave the interior of the classrooms open for use.

A painting studio is located on the top floor

"The exposed concrete structural system not only addresses the project's structural challenges and trapezoidal floor plan but also minimizes long-term maintenance costs," the team explained.

The natural wood floors of the graphic design classroom and soft grey floors of the painting studio are subtly raked, cascading down to a teaching or display area.

Natural light was a key consideration in the design

"The project's greatest success lies in its genuine connection with the children who inhabit it," the studio said.

"By prioritizing experiential richness – through intentional natural light, quality materials and carefully calibrated spatial proportions – the architecture became an integral part of their daily lives and learning."

Other public projects recently completed in Quito include a hillside pavilion for mountain bikers by URLO Studio, a children's play area in a museum placed in a historic factory by Morphism and a restaurant with a rippled, reflective ceiling by Felipe Escudero.

The photography is by JAG Studio.

Project credits:

Architect: Studio Blur

Contractor: Studio Blur

Project team: Aurelio Peñaherrera, Juan Sebastián Cardona, Darwin Sánchez

Structural engineer: Momentum

Mechanical engineer: HYDROGROUP

Electrical engineer: IESCO

Client: Sociedad de Madres Salesianas

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standard-article(title: [Photographing Spring Flowers with Artistic Intent], author: [500px Blog], source-name: [500px ISO], images: (), paragraphs: ([Spring brings a burst of color and renewal, making it the perfect time to explore artistic interpretations of nature through photography. Photographing spring flowers with artistic intent goes beyond documentation, it's about evoking mood, emotion, and story. Here's how to bring a creative lens to your floral captures this season.], [Before clicking the shutter, take a moment to consider what story or mood you want to convey through your image. Are you drawn to soft, romantic aesthetics? Or do you prefer bold colors and graphic shapes? Let this intention guide your composition and post-processing choices.], [Use shallow depth of field (f/2.8–f/4) for dreamy, blurred backgrounds.], [Frame your subject with natural elements to create depth and visual interest.], [Light as Your Creative Partner], [Photographing spring flowers with artistic intent means being intentional with lighting. Natural light, especially during golden hour, can add warmth and texture to your floral scenes.], [Shoot during early morning or late afternoon for soft, diffused light.], [Experiment with backlighting to highlight petal translucency.], [Use a reflector or white surface to gently bounce light and reduce harsh shadows.], [Explore Composition and Perspective], [Change your vantage point to avoid typical top-down shots. Try photographing at flower level, from behind, or even through other foliage for a more immersive and unique perspective.], [Incorporate negative space to evoke serenity or simplicity.], [Try minimalist framing or off-center placement using the rule of thirds.], [Play with Color and Texture], [Spring offers a vibrant color palette. When photographing spring flowers with artistic intent, pay attention to complementary colors and repeating patterns. Let texture and color contrast carry the image's emotion.], [Pro Tip: Create a Floral Series with Purpose], [Instead of one-off shots, consider creating a cohesive photo series that explores a specific flower type, color palette, or compositional theme. This approach encourages consistency, deepens your understanding of visual storytelling, and can be shared as a collection that reflects your unique creative perspective.], [Extended reading: Transforming ordinary scenes with vibrant colors], [The post Photographing Spring Flowers with Artistic Intent appeared first on 500px .],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 343, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

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standard-article(title: [The Many Falls], author: [Stu Davidson], source-name: [Stuck in Customs], images: (), paragraphs: ([Daily Photo – The Many Falls], [One thing (of many good things) that New Zealand does is create and well maintain walking tracks. They're all over the place on the South Island and even from the middle of a town or city you're often only a few minutes from the beginning of a trail that will take you into a beautiful, serene environment where you'll barely see another human. The paths often cross little streams and regularly pass by lovely waterfalls like this one. Great for popping your shoes off and cooling down some tired feet on the way back.], [Date Taken 2025-03-23 12:50:22], [Camera ILCE-7CR], [Exposure Time 1/25], [Aperture 16], [ISO 320], [Focal Length 24.0 mm], [Flash Off, Did not fire], [The post The Many Falls appeared first on Stuck in Customs .],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 158, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

Lego to mark Sagrada Familia completion with largest ever set

Tom Ravenscroft · Dezeen Architecture

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Toy brand Lego is reportedly set to release a model of the Sagrada Familia in Barcelona , which will be the largest set ever created.

Set to be launched as part of the company's Architecture series, the news of the upcoming Lego set was leaked by a long-time leaker known as Chief Wiggum , whose predictions have proven true in the past.

According to the leak, the Lego version of Antoni Gaudí 's Sagrada Familia cathedral will be made of 12,060 pieces, making it the largest set ever released by the toy company. The current biggest set sold by the brand is the Art World Map, which has 11,695 pieces.

Sagrada Familia set to complete this year

Although no official launch date has been announced, the leak suggests that the set will be released this year. This will align the release with the completion of the Sagrada Familia and with the 100th anniversary of Gaudí's death.

Read:

Video reveals Sagrada Familia becoming tallest church in the world

After 140 years, the cathedral is set to be completed this year.

The huge church is topped with 18 spires, including the 170-metre-high central spire, which makes the building the tallest church in the world – almost 10 metres higher than Ulm Minster in Germany.

Latest set in Lego's Architecture series

The set would be the latest in Lego's Architecture series, which was launched in 2008 with the Sears Tower and the John Hancock Center skyscrapers.

Since then, the toy brand has made models of some of the world's most significant works of architecture, including the Solomon R Guggenheim Museum and Fallingwater by Frank Lloyd Wright, Farnsworth House by Ludwig Mies van der Rohe and Villa Savoye by Le Corbusier .

Other significant buildings that have been recreated in Lego sets, including the Empire State Building in New York and Paris's Notre-Dame cathedral and Eiffel Tower.

The post Lego to mark Sagrada Familia completion with largest ever set appeared first on Dezeen .

Construction on the Sagrada Familia, designed by Catalan architect Gaudí as the main cathedral in Barcelona, began in 1882.

Tom Ravenscroft

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ANALYSIS

A History of Film's Greatest Bad Guys and What They Reveal

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

The American Film Institute's list of the '100 greatest heroes and villains' reflects key trends in American cinematic storytelling and the enduring power of specific character archetypes. In effect, the history of bad guys, villains, and enemies is a fascinating story of cinema and society itself. Cinematic antagonists have evolved from simple one-dimensional figures to complex characters demonstrating a psychological understanding of the audience. From the master criminal Fantomas to the highly-sophisticated cannibalistic serial killer, Hannibal Lecter, we continue to be fascinated by these great villains.

In early cinema, villains were often set apart from the hero with a clear role of creating conflict and testing the protagonists. They were primarily motivated by greed, lust for power, or simple malice. Visual cues focused on their physical appearance to project villainy. As such, the bad guys might have facial scars, stern expressions, or portray albinism. For example, the moustache-twirling villain is traced back to Victorian melodrama and early silent films. Exaggerated gestures and facial hair helped convey the character's wickedness. Barney Oldfield's *Race for Life* released in 1913 is widely cited by film historians as the movie that popularized the iconic image of the melodramatic villain. The villain played by Ford Sterling wears a huge, black mustache and is shown gleefully engaging in devious acts often literally twirling his mustache while plotting.

Another key archetype is the Master Criminal - these are intellectual but purely evil characters. Think of Fantomas and Dr. Mabuse, two of the earliest and most terrifying master criminal archetypes in 20th century popular culture. Essentially, these characters created the model for the modern super villain and criminal mastermind. Fantomas is a character from French crime fiction, a criminal genius whose face and true identity remain unknown. Described as a phantom, he often wears the identity of a person he has murdered. On the other hand, Dr. Mabuse is a character from German fiction. Brilliant and educated, he used his knowledge to destroy society. Other important early archetypes are the Classic Monster with figures like Count Dracula and Frankenstein's Monster creating fears of the unknown, the supernatural, and the unchecked science.

During this period, villains started embodying greater social and political anxieties. One such example was Mr. Potter in *It's a Wonderful Life*, representing the danger of unhindered corporate or economic power. The femme fatale concept also began with women like Phyllis Dietrichson in *Double Indemnity* using their allure and beauty to manipulate the male hero to his downfall.

Foreign villains in spy thrillers started to feature prominently in early James Bond films like Auric Goldfinger. Later on, psycho villain characters were introduced bringing in more complex, psychologically disturbed indi-

viduals who just looked like ordinary guys. Hitchcock's *Psycho*, starring Anthony Perkins as Norman Bates, the shy and seemingly normal proprietor of Bates Hotel, explores identity, madness, and the psychological impact of his past.

Flash forward to the 1970s and beyond, and the audience sees a great shift towards three-dimensional villains with complex histories and sinister motivations. A prime example is Darth Vader, a figure of pure evil who is transformed into a tragic corrupt figure. Hollywood films also frequently use hacking scenes to establish a sense of modern danger portraying villains as technologically brilliant and highly dangerous individuals. *Live Free or Die Hard* (2007) dramatically shows a systematic multi-stage cyber-attack that takes down America's transportation, financial, and utility infrastructure.

During the late 70s and 80s, the audience was shown what were basically unstoppable villains. More often than not, they had no clear motive and were pure relentless evil. Michael Myers (*Halloween* series) and Jason Voorhees (*Friday the 13th* series) are two of the most recognized and feared protagonists of the horror movie genre. The 1975 film, *Jaws*, also featured a non-human antagonist in the shape of a great white shark. Films such as *The Joker* (2019) showcased the rise of characters inspired by chaos or extreme ideologies. Likewise, films now tackle conflict within a corrupted system, institution, or society such as Agent Smith in *The Matrix* (1999). Psychological thrillers also continued to represent a modern fascination with and fear of the human psyche, mental illness, and deviance. Hannibal Lecter in *The Silence of the Lambs* (1991) is such an iconic villain because of the extreme contrast between his high culture and barbaric depravity.

The enduring popularity of the film villain suggests that the capacity for evil is not a supernatural force, but a human one. As society grew more complex, so did the vilification of the bad guys evolving from monsters and spies to ideological mayhem and psychological breakdown.

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What Studying History Teaches Students About the Modern World

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

There is a moment most history students experience somewhere around their second or third year of serious study. They are reading about something old, something that feels safely distant, and then they stop. Because the pattern they just read about is happening right now, in the news, in their country, in their own city. That moment is not coincidence. It is the whole point.

History is not a list of dates. It never was. But somewhere between standardized tests and textbook summaries, that idea got lost for a lot of students. The question worth asking is not whether history is interesting. It is what studying it actually does to how a person thinks.

It Builds a Different Kind of Intelligence

The importance of history education is rarely framed in terms of cognitive development, but it probably should be. Reading primary sources, cross-referencing accounts, figuring out why a source exists and who benefits from it are not passive activities. They require students to hold multiple interpretations at once and decide which one is better supported by evidence.

Historians at institutions like Oxford and the University of Chicago have long argued that this kind of analytical work produces skills that transfer far beyond the classroom. History and critical thinking skills are deeply intertwined because the discipline essentially teaches students to distrust easy answers. A student who has spent time studying the lead-up to World War I does not walk away thinking there was one cause. They walk away thinking about systems, pressures, miscalculations, and the role of individual decisions inside structural forces.

When students are working on complex humanities assignments that require structured academic support, capstone project writing services from KingEssays connects them with subject-specific guidance, helping them build arguments rather than simply summarize events.

What the Numbers Say About Historical Literacy

The conversation around why study history often runs into a practical objection: what does it pay? It is a fair question, and the data is more interesting than the skeptics expect.

A 2018 report by the American Historical Association found that history graduates are employed across a wide range of sectors, including business, government, law, and nonprofit work, with earnings that compare favorably to many social science fields over a 10-year career arc. The Association of American Colleges and Universities has consistently found that employers rank critical thinking, written communication, and ethical reasoning as their top desired competencies, all of which history programs develop directly.

The benefits of studying history for students go well beyond cultural knowledge. They include a set of transferable competencies that are increasingly rare in an environment where most educational paths push toward narrow specialization early. For students who need help structuring evidence-based arguments in history and other humanities subjects, services such as this offer academic writing assistance built around analytical work.

Real Events, Real Lessons

Consider the 2008 financial crisis. Many economists who failed to anticipate it had strong quantitative skills but limited understanding of historical financial cycles. Carmen Reinhart and Kenneth Rogoff, in their widely cited work “This Time Is Different,” demonstrated that financial crises follow recognizable historical patterns across centuries and continents. Their argument was essentially a historical one: context and precedent matter, even in modern finance.

Or take the COVID-19 pandemic. Epidemiologists who had studied the 1918 influenza outbreak had a conceptual framework for understanding transmission dynamics, public resistance to health measures, and the social disruption that follows. That framework was not academic decoration. It shaped early policy responses in countries like South Korea and Taiwan, both of which had also experienced SARS in 2003 and retained institutional memory of it.

What does studying history teach you in these cases? It teaches that the present is rarely as unprecedented as it feels. It teaches that human behavior under pressure follows recognizable patterns. And it teaches that people who understand those patterns have a structural advantage over people who do not.

The Civic Dimension Nobody Talks About Enough

There is something else the importance of history education points toward, and it does not get discussed enough in conversations about career outcomes or cognitive skills. History is one of the few disciplines that takes democratic participation seriously as a subject of study.

Students who study the Voting Rights Act of 1965, the mechanics of propaganda in 20th-century totalitarian states, or the long arc of labor movements in industrial Europe are not just learning about the past. They are developing a literacy that helps them interpret political messaging, recognize manipulation, and evaluate institutional claims with something other than pure faith or pure cynicism.

The Stanford History Education Group conducted a study in 2016 that found most American middle and high school students struggled to distinguish between news articles, sponsored content, and opinion pieces online. History education, when taught well, directly addresses this problem. The skills used to evaluate a 17th-century pamphlet and a modern social media post are not that different.

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Eight contemporary houses raised on stilts

Tom Ravenscroft · Dezeen Architecture

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Whether to make sloped sites level, prevent flooding or reduce impact on natural surroundings, houses on stilts are being built around the world. Here are eight of the best contemporary examples.

House in the Delta by MAPA, Argentina

Raised on stilts to protect from periodic flooding on its riverside site near Buenos Aires, House in the Delta was the first Passivhaus-certified home built in Argentina.

Architectural studio MAPA described the home as “an amphibious house – built high above the ground to coexist with the periodic flooding on the banks of the Paraná Mini”.

[Find out more about House in the Delta >](#)

Prat House, by ERRE Arquitectos, Chile

Located in Matanzas, Chile, the 128-square-metre Prat House was designed by Raimundo Gutiérrez of ERRE Arquitectos to take advantage of its coastal site.

The entire single-storey seaside house was elevated on steel stilts, with a raised walkway and timber steps providing access.

[Find out more about Prat House >](#)

Constructed using predominantly light-coloured timber to help it blend with its surroundings, Yngsjö was built as a retreat from city life for a Swedish family based in London.

Located close to the shores of the Baltic Sea, the house is designed to sit lightly on the site with over half the structure raised on slender steel pillars.

[Find out more about Yngsjö >](#)

Architecture studios Jaime Prous Architects and Pineda & Monedero raised this metal-clad home on metal stilts above a steeply sloping site to the east of Barcelona.

Created for a retired couple who wanted an escape from the city, Casa 144° is lifted off the ground to minimise its impact on the landscape.

[Find out more about Casa 144° >](#)

Described by its architect as “a contemporary chalet in harmony with its environment”, this cedar-clad residence was raised above a sloped site overlooking the St Lawrence River in Québec.

Quinzhee Architecture designed the 129-square-metre ski house to take advantage of its site and surrounding views.

[Find out more about Residence Chez Léon >](#)

The aptly named Hole with the House Around comprises a series of boxy volumes raised on stilts surrounding a central void.

Architecture studio ElasticoFarm designed the structure as an extension to an existing 1970s house surrounded by trees in an Italian park in Cambiano, a town to the southeast of Turin.

[Find out more about Hole with the House Around >](#)

Saunders Architecture designed this house overlooking a lake in Norway for the descendants of Norwegian composer Edvard Grieg.

Named Villa Grieg, the house combines a two-bedroom home with a music studio. The sloped music studio sits on the ground floor, with stairs leading up to the raised home that winds around a central void.

[Find out more about Villa Grieg >](#)

The majority of this angular, lily-shaped home was raised on stilts to prevent the unnecessary removal of trees from its site in a lush Brazilian forest.

According to the studio, the black stilts that support the house were placed at “random” to emulate how trees grow in a forest.

[Find out more about Casa Açucena >](#)

The post Eight contemporary houses raised on stilts appeared first on Dezeen .

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Bipartisan House bill seeks to curb officials' prediction market trading

Jacob Woodward · ReadWrite

Two House lawmakers from opposite parties are pushing new legislation they say would stop federal officials from cashing in on inside knowledge through prediction markets.

Rep. Adrian Smith, a Republican from Nebraska, and Rep. Nikki Budzinski, a Democrat from Illinois, introduced the Preventing Real-time Exploitation and Deceptive Insider Congressional Trading Act, known as the PREDICT Act, on March 25. Their proposal responds to the rapid rise of online platforms that let users wager on the outcomes of elections, policy decisions, and global events.

If passed, the bill would bar members of Congress, their spouses, and dependent children from trading on prediction markets tied to political or government actions. The same restrictions would extend to the president, vice president, and senior political appointees across the executive branch.

Anyone who breaks the proposed rules would face a civil fine equal to 10% of the value of the banned trade. They would also be required to surrender any profits from those transactions, with the money going to the U. S. Treasury.

Backers of the legislation argue that prediction markets have grown quickly and now present a new avenue for potential insider trading that existing ethics laws may not fully cover.

“Serving the American people is a privilege, not a pathway to profit. Our commonsense, bipartisan bill will give Americans confidence that the decisions of their elected officials are guided by merit, not personal profit. I am proud to partner with Representative Budzinski to ensure that government officials do not profit from the sensitive information entrusted to them,” Smith said in a statement when announcing the legislation.

Budzinski said recent high-profile bets tied to global conflicts and domestic political standoffs show how lucrative these markets can be for those with the right information.

“The American people are tired of politicians using their influence for personal gain, and the rise of prediction markets has made those concerns even more relevant. In recent months, we’ve seen instances of little-known traders making massive profits on events ranging from war with Iran to how long a government shutdown will last, raising necessary questions about the use of inside information,”

She added that the legislation is intended to “close that loophole and ensure that those with access to sensitive information cannot profit from it.”

The House effort comes as lawmakers in the Senate have been examining similar concerns. Separate bipartisan proposals have sought to restrict or ban certain types of event-

based and sports-related prediction markets, with supporters arguing they blur the line between financial products and unregulated gambling. Those measures reflect a growing unease in Washington over how quickly these platforms are expanding and how they are overseen.

Legal battles have also intensified. In Nevada, a federal court recently blocked the prediction market platform Kalshi from offering certain event contracts in the state, siding with regulators who argued the products resembled sports betting.

The decision just showcases the unsettled regulatory landscape facing the industry and why some lawmakers say clearer federal rules are needed.

For now, the PREDICT Act has been referred for consideration in the House, where it will face committee review before any potential floor vote.

Its introduction adds to a broader bipartisan push to tighten ethics rules and close perceived gaps that allow public officials to profit from their positions.

The post Bipartisan House bill seeks to curb officials' prediction market trading appeared first on ReadWrite .

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Roman Trade with Modern-Day Sri Lanka

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

When Roman sailors and merchants in the first centuries of the Common Era looked southward from the mouth of the Red Sea, the island they called Taprobane, now almost universally identified with Sri Lanka, appeared in their geographies as a rich and mysterious partner in an expanding Indian Ocean trade network. Classical geographers and travel writers treated Taprobane both as a place of fabulous commodities and as a real staple of long-distance exchange: it appears in the *Periplus of the Erythraean Sea*, in Pliny the Elder's *Natural History*, and on Ptolemy's maps, and these accounts, read together with archaeological finds around Sri Lanka's ancient ports, make a persuasive case that Greco-Roman traders reached the island's shores, if sometimes indirectly, from the mid-first century CE onward.

The short but vivid *Periplus of the Erythraean Sea*, a Greek seaman's handbook usually dated to the mid-first century CE, is the most direct contemporary Roman-period testimony to long-distance navigation in the Indian Ocean. Its anonymous author describes routes, seasons and goods, and although Taprobane receives briefer treatment than the western Indian ports, the *Periplus* places the island within the author's pragmatic commercial map: it is a known source of gems, ivory and other sought-after products and a waypoint for ships that ranged along the eastern Indian seaboard and beyond. The *Periplus* also reflects the adoption of the monsoon crossing, knowledge of seasonal wind patterns credited to figures such as Hippalus, which made regular oceanic linkages between the Red Sea and South Asia feasible and economically attractive for Roman subjects based in Egypt.

Pliny the Elder and Ptolemy amplify the picture of Taprobane as an object of classical curiosity and commerce. Pliny compiled earlier reports and travelers' tales into his encyclopedic *Natural History* and explicitly names Taprobane among the distant islands whose products reached Mediterranean markets; Ptolemy's *Geographia*, meanwhile, institutionalized Taprobane on maps, even if the island's scale and position were distorted in late antique cartography. These literary testimonies outline what the Roman-world readers believed they were buying from the Indian Ocean: not only luxury items such as pearls, gems, spices and exotic woods, but also useful commodities—elephants for war and ivory for luxury works—that made a voyage to Taprobane, or through agents who dealt with it, commercially worthwhile.

Textual notice must be matched to material traces, and here archaeology supplies concrete, if sometimes contested, evidence. Excavations and survey work at Sri Lanka's ancient trading sites—most notably Mantai (the harbor complex at Mannar), Godavaya and certain finds around the southern ports and the Ruhuna region—have produced imported ceramics, Indo-Roman wares, and metal finds datable to the first few centuries CE. These finds indicate

that goods and perhaps persons moved between the island and the wider Indian Ocean economy at the time classical authors wrote. Archaeologists have recovered Roman or Roman-style amphora sherds and Mediterranean imports mixed with local and South Indian ceramics in contexts that often line up with the mid-first through third centuries CE, supporting the textual evidence that Taprobane was part of long-distance trade networks rather than an isolated curiosity.

Numismatics has contributed one of the most headline-grabbing types of evidence: Roman and Indo-Roman coins found on the island and in neighboring Indian ports. Scholars have catalogued a variety of coins—official Roman denominations, later Byzantine and Sasanian pieces, and locally struck imitations, that turn up in hoards and stray finds across Sri Lanka's archaeological record. The presence of Roman gold, silver and bronze specimens, and of imitations that adapt Roman portraiture and types, demonstrates multiple channels of contact: direct importation, trade mediated by South Indian merchants, and the island's participation in a wider monetary ecology that incorporated foreign coinage as bullion or prestige money. At the same time, numismatists caution that coin deposits are slippery evidence for regular commercial routes, coins travel, are hoarded, reused and sometimes arrive centuries after they were minted, so they illuminate connectivity without always proving direct, continuous Roman state involvement.

Material culture beyond coins, such as fragments of Mediterranean amphorae, glassware and certain classically styled objects helps round out the picture. Amphora sherds linked by form and fabric to Mediterranean production argue that Mediterranean foodstuffs (wine, preserved fish or oil) or at least their containers were carried into the Indian Ocean system. Yet many of the "Roman" finds in South Asia were funneled through intermediary entrepôts on the Malabar coast and the Arabian littoral; the principal agents of exchange in this era were often Indian, Arabian and later Southeast Asian merchants who operated the coastal networks and transshipped cargoes to and from Sri Lankan anchors. Consequently, although Roman subjects and merchants surely appear among the actors of this commerce, especially in Egyptian port cities like Berenice and Myos Hormos—the day-to-day movement of goods to Taprobane seems to have been largely run by regional middlemen who connected Mediterranean markets to South Asian and island producers.

Certain Sri Lankan exports made the island especially prized by Mediterranean consumers. Classical authors and later commentators repeatedly emphasize cinnamon (whose precise identification in ancient texts is debated), pearls from the island's offshore banks, high-quality gemstones and ivory. Archaeology confirms the island's role in pearl fishing and its access to precious stones and fine timber, while epigraphic and local traditions record long-standing maritime commerce. The intersection of demand in the Roman world for luxury consumables and Sri Lanka's

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Sectionalism: Understanding the Divisions that Led to the U.S. Civil War

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

The American Civil War still fascinates the public mind for its timeless reminder of when our politics were truly at their nadir. Despite some contemporary warnings about a national separation, fortunately no such moment has come to pass since the cannons ceased and the muskets were put down in 1865. Intense vitriol and hatred over the state of this country is something no specific to the war period. Whether it be 1860, 1828, or the 1800 election that saw friends become bitter rivals in outgoing President John Adams and incoming President Thomas Jefferson cease communicate for several years, national politics endures as a nasty business.

Yet, in our memory of the Civil War and its causes, we tend to let the latter fall by the wayside, consequently forgetting how unique those divisions were in the 1850s, culminating in southern secession in December 1860 after President Abraham Lincoln's victory. Slavery was the cause as evidenced by the declarations from the southern states [i] , but how many grasp slavery as the sectional issue that it was? Where does sectionalism fit into our memory? Without a more holistic understanding of the war through the sectional crisis that preceded it, we let more simplistic interpretations of why it started take over.

What is sectionalism and why is the period preceding the war defined as the Sectional Crisis? To answer that question, it is important first to define a section. As Professor Richard Benseal puts it, a section is a, "major geographic region." [1] In this context, the sections that fought would be the North and South. Sectionalism, then, is the unique culture and economic tendencies emerging in those regions that create a politics of their own. A sectional politics does not have a national vision – one for the country as a whole – in mind, but whatever agenda best serves this cluster of states. The Civil War is a war between North and South, but just as accurately, a war of sections. It was not so simple as to say Republicans and Democrats fought with the former looking to limit slavery's spread and the latter seeking to keep it.

The Democrats themselves were divided over the issue of slavery. In 1860, Southern Democrats did not feel enough assurance was given by candidate and Illinois Senator Stephen Douglas that their institution would be defended. They opted to nominate their own candidate, Vice President John C. Breckenridge of Kentucky. The electoral map speaks to this division with the southern states going for him. [2] When looking at a breakdown of the popular vote, the University of Richmond does not record a single vote for Douglas in the southern state of Texas. [3]

Looking further back, divisions among Democrats over slavery preceded the Sectional Crisis as is exemplified by the Wilmot Proviso. Democratic Pennsylvania Representative David Wilmot introduced a proviso to President James K Polk's \$2 million appropriations bill allocating funds to

negotiations with Mexico. This was August 8, 1846 during the Mexican-American War. In that proviso, Wilmot proposed,

as an express and fundamental condition to the acquisition of any territory from the Republic of Mexico by the United States, by virtue of any treaty which may be negotiated between them, and to the use by the Executive of the moneys herein appropriated, neither slavery nor involuntary servitude shall ever exist in any part of said territory, except for crime, whereof the party shall first be duly convicted. [4]

This was effectively Northern Democrats telling their southern colleagues they would not tow a line for slavery only for the sake of party unity. [5] Democrats did not have a pro or anti-slavery platform. They struggled to unify under one position towards the issue.

To be sure, from its inception, the Republican Party was northern-based. Multiple southern states did not cast a single vote for their candidate John C Fremont in the party's first national election, the Election of 1856. [6] The North was not entirely Republican, but the Republicans were – almost – entirely in the North. In the modern era, parties have their strongholds. Democrats do better in New England, other coastal areas, and urban centers while Republicans capture the South and Midwest. Geography does correlate to politics on the electoral map and that observation largely holds true in our elections, but the question during the sectional crisis was not one of partisanship, but of sectional allegiances. For Southern Democrats, never mind where their northern brethren were heading, as they assessed the situation, they needed to make their own way.

An emphasis on the sectional dimension of this conflict dispels later assertions that the Democratic Party was the party of slavery. Southern Democrats supported it, but sectional divisions fly in the face of an argument for party unity. Studying sectionalism leaves us with a complex web of geopolitically motivated behaviors and allegiances that historians strive to make sense of in forming a meta-narrative for the war's causes. Studies are made more complicated when considering examples out of the South that push back against the conclusion of consensus being for slavery and against Lincoln. How are we to regard President Andrew Johnson, who, as a congressman from Tennessee – and Democrat –, was the only senator from a seceding state to remain in the Union? This is a man who historians studying his life have admitted it is hard to arrive at any definitive statements about when looking at his character. [7] More broadly, estimates say 100,000 men living in the Confederate states served the Union during the war. [8] Among them, Virginia-born Union General George Thomas, a slave owner before the war, alienated his family who refused to speak to him for fighting against the South. [9]

In history or contemporary politics, neat and tidy conclusions about politics, allegiances, or where one falls of the political spectrum for their views on divisive issues are few and far between. If we are to understand political

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History, Not Histrionics. Facts, not Factoids

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

History is an art in a sense. That is, it is not mathematically provable. The mathematician (I am one, at least through some bit of graduate studies) must prove something logically (there are certain basic rules of logic—contrary to reflections from “the squad,” et al). If he can’t prove it, it simply means it is not provable true, nor is it provable false. It may be either but it is neither, absent a deterministic logical proof. Such problems wait to see if one may ever find a proof (such as the recently and famously proven “Fermat’s Last Theorem”). Many, many today fall into the yet unknown true or false class. For those interested, an excellent book for a layman’s (most) comprehension of one of the most famous problems, is John Derbyshire’s Prime Obsession, summarizing The Riemann Hypothesis.

The scientific method of proof (different from the mathematical proof) in the physical sciences is proved by sampling and testing to the point of reproducing such results in the laboratory. These are scientific-method determined proofs. Jonas Salk’s polio vaccine work is an example of a proof by the scientific method. Climate change study is an example of a crock of crap.

But the historian has no logical proof of his art since history is what it was. You cannot associate an abstract thought with a concrete fact of the past in order to change the fact. But this is exactly what “liberals” do. (The quotation marks are a tweaking of the modern definition of liberal as opposed to the once accepted and true one—but another story for another day.)

Liberals will suggest silliness (though they believe it is serious thought, perhaps) such as Lincoln was responsible for a horrible war that resulted in well over half a million deaths and billions of dollars of destruction of private property and on and on with a political wrecking ball of death by fire and murder as well as the raping and pillaging of both blacks and whites, male and female, and so on. BUT, the great defensible BUT, he was trying to save the union. This is, in fact, abstraction smothering fact. I say “liberals will suggest” when the fact is they state it as the fact that they have proven, even though facts of history are not provable but revealed from recorded sources.

The fact is he was no more trying to save the union than he was trying to free the slaves. He (and many, many Republican cronies), like Hamilton before him, wanted to create a national state. i.e. a nation.

How irony raises its fortuitous head from time to time? Abe Lincoln was assigned the label “Honest” Abe. However, when digging into history and available primary sources reveal the guy as a notorious liar and charlatan. If Lincoln lived today, he would be in bed with the Clintons (at least one of them) when it came to honesty. Alas, Lincoln’s reputation remains largely untainted by those

who worship the faux pas of some rotted theory of national conservatism.

But another historical faux pas (of the many) that seems a lesser light of historical fiction is about a man who was president but had a more honorable reputation. Though, sadly influenced by the liar, Alexander Hamilton.

George Washington never (contrary to modern legend) had offers to be king. The myth is that he was so well respected that a crown was offered to him. There was also a myth cultivated due to his honest character: That is, he did not lie. The myth was the one most everyone has heard: he cut down a cherry tree, then fessed up when asked. But neither tale—crown offering or cherry-tree-chopping—was true about Washington. However, most historians have recorded him as a man of integrity.

So it is that good tales are created about someone who has a good reputation for honesty. At least most of the time. But the “creation” is not a fact. It is just supposedly true.

All of the evidence may not be available, but all that is should be examined.

George Levrier-Jones

But the real historian is like a prospector—always digging, always sifting facts from rumor and/or legend. The primary or original source (I am not a historian, but am a history student), or as close to it as one can get to begin a study is the best beginning. From the beginning of whatever historical-to-present goal is sought the trail is like the trail of evidence in a crime. That is to say that great danger can come to the truth if the trail is broken. All of the evidence may not be available, but all that is should be examined. Therefore, the trail route (the history) can be surmised with a given degree of accuracy.

Around us, primarily through online chatter, social media, and the monster maniacal media of television fame are those historian-labeled personalities, many who are promoted (many self) as PhDs of some grandiloquent history department of “XYZ” university—blah. Blah, blah. These types and their schools are worthy of the aforementioned climate change students. Many (most?) of the media-type historians are just airbags who get a nice paycheck.

Or there are the puffed-up Twitter et chirps who glorify themselves in some modern cloak of Thucydides such as the “spit and damn” clownish Kevin Levin (as just one example) who tops out as a racist of the first liberal order. No? His mentions of historical studies and insights of the American War Between the States are the typical Yankee sighting and portraying of the American South with its blacks as simple-minded toadies following “Massuh-Cotton-Man” to every beat of the drum because he (the black

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standard-article(title: [X Architects unveils Grand Mosque “for rapidly changing Riyadh”], author: [Starr Charles], source-name: [Dezeen Architecture], images: (), paragraphs: ([style=“margin-bottom: 15px;”>], [Dubai-based X Architects has revealed plans for the Grand Mosque in Riyadh , Saudi Arabia, which will be fronted by a stacked minaret.], [Planned to be built alongside Wadi Hanifah in Diriyah, the complex will house prayer halls alongside public facilities and planted courtyards across its 21,690-square-metre plot.], [X Architects has designed the Grand Mosque in Riyadh], [The project was conceived by X Architects as a “civic anchor” for the wider Diriyah Gate II development, which forms part of the Saudi Vision 2030 initiative.], [“Our ambition was to design a mosque fit for a twenty-first-century, rapidly changing Riyadh, but one that carries its spiritual, civic and climatic responsibilities with enough depth so that it can serve many generations to come,” studio co-founder Ahmed Al Ali said.], [It will be fronted by a stacked minaret], [X Architects drew on the region’s traditional Najdi architecture for the mosque’s textured lattice facades, describing the building as a “contemporary Najdi landmark”.], [Renders of the complex reveal its 12,300-square-metre volume carved with triangular openings and illuminated at night. Once complete, the monument will accommodate up to 11,400 visitors, according to the studio.], [“The Grand Mosque is shaped by the specific grain of Diriyah – its mud-brick heritage, the scale of the boulevard, the topography of Wadi Hanifah – and by the very real daily patterns of residents and visitors who will experience this sacred space,” studio co-founder Farid Esmaeil said.], [Its lattice facades will be punctuated with triangular openings], [At its street-facing front, the mosque will be signposted by a stacked minaret, which will have a matching latticed form. From here, a stepped entrance framed by a deep triangular portal is set to guide visitors into the complex via a shaded passage.], [Within the complex, a central plaza will be used to host Eid prayers as well as community events and weekend markets.], [Thick lattice walls with triangular openings will wrap around the volume to serve as a “porous edge” between the internal and external courtyards.], [Read:], [In line with the Ministry of Islamic Affairs mosque guidelines, the Grand Mosque will include both male and female prayer halls, ablution areas, and an external sahn, alongside classrooms, offices, a library and cafe.], [Renders of the interior spaces reveal the lofty prayer halls, where lattice screens will filter in dappled light.], [The lattice screens will filter dappled light across the interiors], [Elsewhere in Saudi Arabia, Snøhetta has topped a metro station with a mirrored bowl-shaped canopy and OODA has unveiled designs for a training facility for Al Nassr FC .], [The renders are courtesy of X Architects.], [The post X Architects unveils Grand Mosque “for rapidly changing Riyadh” appeared first on Dezeen .],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 462, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

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standard-article(title: [This week OMA completed its extension of the New Museum in Manhattan], author: [Amy Peacock], source-name: [Dezeen Architecture], images: (), paragraphs: ([style=“margin-bottom: 15px;”>], [This week on Dezeen , we revealed OMA’s angular expansion of the SANAA-designed New Museum in Manhattan, New York.], [The extension doubles the museum’s footprint with added galleries and social spaces, which are concealed behind a facade that was designed to have a unique appearance compared to its blocky predecessor.], [Also this week, Corinthian columns were proposed for the White House], [Controversy over the development of White House continued this week, as Commission of Fine Arts chair Rodney Mims Cook Jr suggested swapping the building’s Ionic columns for Corinthian to match the in-progress ballroom extension.], [Also as part of US president Donald Trump’s revamp of the White House, architecture studio AECOM unveiled its design for a subterranean visitor screening centre , which would be built under the nearby Sherman Park.], [Edward Peck Design proposed a translucent canopy for the Chicago Bears’ stadium], [Elsewhere in the USA, architecture studio Edward Peck Design revealed its proposal to add a translucent canopy to the Chicago Bears’ stadium in an effort to convince the NFL team to stay in the city.], [The concept was developed to show how the existing stadium could be adapted to meet the need for a next-generation stadium, with a roof, expanded seating and an entertainment complex.], [In other architecture news, Italian studio Stefano Boeri Interiors revamped a piazza outside the Colosseum in Rome.], [The semicircular outdoor space features 44 raised stone benches, which were placed to mark the footprints of original columns that once stood on the ancient Roman site.], [Researchers recycled plastic bottles into a Parkinson’s drug using bacteria], [University of Edinburgh researchers made advances in “bio-upcycling” this week, when they successfully used bacteria to turn plastic waste into a Parkinson’s drug .], [The process involved breaking down polyethylene terephthalate (PET) plastic and feeding it to genetically engineered E. coli bacteria, which built it back up again with a different molecular structure to form the drug L-DOPA.], [A home elevated on steel stilts was among the most popular projects this week], [Popular projects on Dezeen this week included a metal-clad home perched on steel stilts in Barcelona, a home extension in London with a timber-framed porch and a house in Saitama , Japan, that features moving walls.], [Listen to our journalists talk about the key design and architecture stories of the past seven days on our Dezeen Weekly podcast, which this week focused on a study indicating that architecture is highly exposed to automation .], [This week on Dezeen], [This week on Dezeen is our regular roundup of the week’s top news stories. Subscribe to our newsletters to be sure you don’t miss anything.], [The post This week OMA completed its extension of the New Museum in Manhattan appeared first on Dezeen .],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 468, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

Josh Ilano, The Architect's Newspaper: Ghana-based Limbo Museum has partnered with Art Omi to present Limbo Engawa, an architectural installation by TAELO7. The piece opened on March 12 in Accra, Ghana, with plans to travel

The post TAELO7 crafts salvaged billboards into an installation for Limbo Museum and Art Omi appeared first on The Architect's Newspaper .

Bret Adams, Vintage Guitar Magazine: For almost 40 years, Frank Hannon has enjoyed success as co-founder and lead guitarist of hard-rockers Tesla. He has also released a few solo albums, none of which are more emotional than Reflections, his new release consisting of 12 original guitar instrumentals in a variety of styles inspired by personal difficulties including the April '24 [...]

Daniel barr, Elastic Blog: AI moves fast, but risk and complexity are rising. As AI matures, strong foundations matter. Elastic delivers search, observability, and security with vector search and retrieval, helping organizations build systems that stay flexible and resilient.

Udayasimha Theepireddy (Uday), Rekha Thangellapalli, Elastic Blog: Accenture and Elastic have jointly developed a unified, AI-ready knowledge base called the Data Readiness Engine. Available now on the AWS Marketplace, it helps organizations prepare enterprise data for advanced GenAI applications.

Calin Van Paris, Yoga Journal: In a high-tech, hot-wired world, we've almost forgotten how to do it. Here are some tips for liberating the most important energy source we've got: our own breath.

The post Are You Breathing Wrong? Here's How to Get More Out of Your Inhalations and Exhalations. appeared first on Yoga Journal .

Stu Davidson, Stuck in Customs: class="daily-photo-object">

class="daily-title">

Daily Photo – Mountain Layers

A familiar view from one range to another. It's heading into spring here now (in reverse season land) so not long until all signs of snow are gone...

class="daily-photo">

class="daily-overlay">

class="daily-overlay-title">

class="hide-1600 visible-sm" style="margin-top: 6px;">Mountain Layers

class="daily-photo-info">

class="hidden-phone photo-h3"> Photo Information

Date Taken 2026-03-29 12:47:40

Camera

Camera Make

Exposure Time

Aperture

ISO

Focal Length

Flash

Exposure Program

Exposure Bias

The post Mountain Layers appeared first on Stuck in Customs .

Omer Kushmaro, Elastic Blog: Elastic Cloud Serverless APIs have no version numbers and won't break; they're managed like any SaaS service. This post busts five common myths from upgrade planning to architecture and compares the versioned Elastic Stack to Serverless.

Willie G. Moseley, Vintage Guitar Magazine: The annals of country music include a legendary narrative that intertwines Chet Atkins and the patriarch of the musical Everly family. In the early 1950s, Ike Everly was a renowned thumbstyle guitarist who, while performing with his wife, Margaret, and sons Don and Phil, influenced Atkins and others including fellow Muhlenberg County native Merle Travis. [...]

Matthew Sedacca, Curbed: Hanya Yanagihara is making quite a few moves. The author of A Little Life is leaving T magazine, where she's currently editor-in-chief, to "pursue opportunities in theater." She is also, we noticed, trying to sel... More »

Clio Chang, Curbed: It's a bad time to be a Transportation Security Officer at La Guardia. A fatal crash closed the airport Monday morning, leaving travelers with canceled flights and winding, hourslong security lines — which only compounded the challenges of week five of a government shutdown that has forced TSA of... More »

Pete Prown, Vintage Guitar Magazine: Teaming up with harpist Johnny Mastro, singer/guitarist Ian Siegal delivers ferocious blues on Easy Tiger, which was cut live at Bigtone Studios in New Orleans. Working with ancient recording gear and a cookin' band, Siegal and Mastro, with co-guitarist Smokehouse Brown, deliver a mighty payload of roadhouse blues and rock and roll intensity. Easy Tiger [...]

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